
ECON 212 — Principles of Microeconomics

Fall 2026

Instructor: Prof. Peter Doe

Location: Science Center 3130

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Meetings: Sec. 01 MWF 8:30–9:20AM; Sec. 02 MWF 9:30–10:20AM

Office: Van Zoeren Hall 165A

Credit Hours: 3.0

Office Hours My office is Van Zoeren Hall 165A, and my office hours are **by appointment here**. All office hours are held **in person in my office** unless you request Zoom. If you are struggling in this course, I highly recommend visiting me.



Scan to book

Course Description & Preparation

Course Description (*From the course catalog*) An introduction to economic analysis at the microeconomic level which focuses on individual and firm decision-making in a market environment. This course deals with such topics as consumer demand, costs of production and supply, resource allocation, the role of competition in markets, labor and resource markets and the economics of the environment.

Course Description (*My version*) This course is a study of the properties and intricacies of markets. We start with a deep dive into supply and demand, where we see the power of markets to allocate resources efficiently. We then examine how and why markets might *fail* to live up to this promise. Next, we tackle market structure and firm behavior: how many sellers are there? how is the price set? Finally, we turn to the markets for the factors of production, with a particular interest in labor markets.

Required Resources & Materials The required textbook for this course is the **11th edition** of Mankiw's *Principles of Microeconomics* ([link](#)). Every person enrolled in this course is automatically charged for one semester of access to Cengage's *MindTap* online learning system (at a better-than-usual rate), which includes an electronic copy of the 11th edition. Because your problem sets are delivered through *MindTap*, the 11th edition is the operative one regardless of what else sits on your shelf. Purchasing a physical copy is therefore **unnecessary**, though some students find one helpful.

Method/Mode of Instruction This course is taught **in person** with the exception of two scheduled virtual classes.

Student Learning Outcomes This course contributes to the following learning outcomes associated with the Economics major:

1. *Critical Thinking*: Enhanced ability to integrate (a) applied and theoretical experiences, and (b) a deep understanding of the content in economics and business, in analytical, problem-solving and creative activities.
4. *Ability to use economic theory*: The ability to use economic theory to analyze economic phenomena.

Evaluation

Grading Assignment grades will be weighted as follows:

Category	Weight
Professionalism	10%
Problem Sets	5%
Presentations and Reports	10%
First Midterm	15%
Second Midterm	15%
Third Midterm	15%
Final Exam	30%

Letter grades are assigned as follows:

Grade	Cutoff	Grade	Cutoff
A	≥93	C	≥73
A-	≥90	C-	≥70
B+	≥87	D+	≥67
B	≥83	D	≥63
B-	≥80	D-	≥60
C+	≥77	F	<60

All grades except professionalism will be updated in Moodle. Moodle does not apply these category weights, so the total it displays is not your actual grade. I do not round grades up.

Professionalism Presenting oneself in a professional manner is fundamental to success in all academic disciplines. To encourage this, I award points across the three **P.I.E.** categories: preparation, initiative, and engagement:

1. **Preparation**: You complete the daily reading quizzes and the syllabus quiz. Each quiz completed on time and correctly contributes 1 point.
2. **Initiative**: You take the first step, whether in arranging a meeting or in asking for particular class materials. Communications with me that demonstrate this will be awarded 1 or 2 points.
3. **Engagement**: You ask and answer relevant questions in class. Points are awarded for each class according to the following scale:

Level of Question or Answer	Points
Attendance only	1
Any quality	2
Excellent	3
Outstanding	4

Your grade for the professionalism category of this course will be determined relative to the scores of your peers. I will sum your points across all three categories to get your *raw score*. I will then compute a *z-score* for each student.¹ Students with a *z-score* of 0 will receive 80% of the grade for the professionalism category. (*Layman's terms: the average raw score gets 8 out of 10 points.*) Each standard deviation above or below the mean is worth 20% of the professionalism grade. (*Layman's terms: In a class of 20 students, 3 will earn a 100% or greater, while 3 will earn a 60% or lower.*) I will keep a running document with your professionalism score. You may ask me at any time to see your current score.

Additionally, I will grant four *awards* per exam based upon your professionalism categories. Each award is worth 2 points on that exam.

1. *Captain Obvious*: Most classes with a 2 or higher score.
2. *General Interesting*: Most classes with a 3 or higher score.
3. *President Prepared*: Most completed reading quizzes.
4. *Extra-Credit Cadet*: Most points in the *initiative* category.

Problem Sets All problem sets are posted on Moodle (with the exception of the syllabus quiz located at the end of this syllabus, which is due in hard copy at the start of class on the **first Friday of the semester**). For most problem sets, Moodle is linked with Cengage's *MindTap* (see above). When you go to complete your first problem set, make sure to access it through Moodle, which will then prompt you to log into Cengage to get the accounts linked. Your grades from *MindTap* will then appear in Moodle.

Problem sets will be **due at 5PM on Wednesday**. Each Wednesday problem set can include material up to the Friday before. For example, if the last lecture on chapter 5 occurs on a Friday, then the homework for chapter 5 is due on the following Wednesday at 5 PM. I will generally announce these dates in class.

It is my policy to not evaluate individual cases for homework exemption (except for DAR accommodations, which I always accept). Because you may sometimes face extenuating circumstances, **I drop your lowest three homework grades**. Please do not ask for homework extensions unless there are technical difficulties.

Presentations and Reports Critical to mastering economics is learning to see the world through the

¹This is a statistical way of describing a raw score relative to the other raw scores.

eyes of economic models. As part of a team, you will identify connections between course content and real-world problems, policies, and pundits, producing a written report and a brief three-slide lightning presentation that critically analyze a policy or pundit tied to the section's content. *Full instructions and the format guide are in the separate **Reports & Presentations** handout on Moodle.*

Exams There will be three midterm exams. If you have a schedule conflict with a midterm exam, we can work out an alternate exam time. If no alternate time is reasonable, then the weight on your final exam will be increased to compensate for the missed midterm examination. *All arrangements (either for a different time or for shifting weight to the final) must be made **before** the originally scheduled exam.* Additionally, this policy may only be used on one exam.

Date	Exam	Chapters (tentative)
Friday, September 25	Exam 1 — How Markets Work	5, 6, 7
Friday, October 23	Exam 2 — When Markets Fail	8, 9, 10, 11, special lecture
Wednesday, November 18	Exam 3 — Firm Behavior	14, 15, 16
8:30AM class: Thursday, December 17th	Final Exam (9:00–11:00AM)	17, 18, 19, 20 + cumulative
9:30AM class: Thursday, December 17th	Final Exam (3:00–5:00PM)	

My Policies

Exam Policies You are allowed to bring in a *hand-written* study guide for each exam. It must be on a 3 × 5 notecard. For the final, you are allowed 4 such study guides.

Any other form of assistance on an exam (other kinds of notes, the internet, AI, passing notes, hacking my computer, etc.) is a violation of academic honesty. Cheating on an exam may result in receiving a zero for that exam and/or failing the class.

Typically, the first 20 points out of 100 on an exam are given “for free.” These are a reserve of points which I might draw against for answers that demonstrate that you do not know what you do not know. It is better to state only what you know (or rather state clearly what you *don't* know) than to make up some poppycock that sounds vaguely correct.

Generative AI

“With great power comes great responsibility.” – *Uncle Ben*

“... and sometimes great nonsense” – *ChatGPT*

You *may absolutely use AI tools for **out-of-class assignments***; in-class assignments are covered in the Exam Policies section. For your reports and presentations I expect them to be polished and immaculate. In the same way that spelling errors are a sign of inattentiveness rather than a foible in

the age of spellcheck, clumsily formatted documents receive no compassion when an LLM sits by your side. You can (and are encouraged to) use these tools to learn the course material as well.

However, *you* (the human...) are responsible for anything submitted to me. You must master the content—Claude can't do that for you! 95% of your grade depends on *in-class* assignments. My heart is not inclined to show mercy to students who AI their way through the homework and somehow run aground on the midterm.

Tentative Schedule A week-by-week schedule of topics, readings, and exam dates is tentative and subject to change. It is provided on the separate **Tentative Schedule** handout distributed alongside this syllabus and posted on Moodle.

Technology In Class *Our classroom is a **no screen zone**—technology use carries *negative externalities*, and a phone distracts your neighbors as much as you. *Each violation costs 1 percentage point off your final score.* You may request an exemption by email (and must receive approval) for a compelling reason, such as a stylus tablet for notes or a DAR accommodation.*

Grade Disputes If you wish to dispute a grade, you must do so within 3 class days of receiving the grade. Keeping short accounts is an important life skill—just as I promptly return your exams, I expect you to read the markup in a timely manner.

Disclaimer This syllabus is subject to change. Any updates will be communicated via email and/or Moodle.

Institutional Policies

Hope College Policies Standard college policies—academic assistance, academic honesty, accommodations, attendance, inclement weather, safety, and student complaints—apply to this course. They are collected on the separate **Hope College Policies** sheet distributed alongside this syllabus and posted on Moodle.

Syllabus Quiz

Name: _____

Date: _____

Answer each question below. Every answer can be found directly in the text of this syllabus. This quiz is due **at the start of class** on the first Friday of the semester (Friday, September 4th). Correctly answering all four questions is worth 1 point toward your Preparation score.

1. My office hours are best described as:

- (a) Walk-in only, weekday mornings, no appointment needed.
- (b) By appointment, and always held over Zoom.
- (c) By appointment via the scheduling link, in person in Van Zoeren Hall 165A unless you request Zoom.
- (d) Not offered; all questions must be handled by email.

2. Your Professionalism grade is determined by:

- (a) Your raw P.I.E. score converted to a z-score relative to your peers.
- (b) The instructor's subjective impression of your attitude.
- (c) A flat 10% awarded to every student who attends regularly.
- (d) Your performance on the syllabus quiz alone.

3. The classroom's Technology In Class policy is best described as:

- (a) Unrestricted, since this is a college class.
- (b) Laptops permitted, phones prohibited.
- (c) Screens permitted only during exams.
- (d) A no-screen zone, with violations costing 1 percentage point off your final score.

4. Regarding homework (problem set) grades, the instructor:

- (a) Grants individual extensions for any reasonable excuse.
- (b) Drops your lowest three homework grades and grants no individual exemptions (except DAR).
- (c) Does not accept late homework under any circumstance, including DAR accommodations.
- (d) Drops your lowest homework grade only.